other country. It will, equally importantly, become the shortest route from mainland China to the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean. The port of Kolkata is just 725 kilometres away from the Tibet frontier in Sikkim. In contrast, the China–Pakistan corridor is over 1500 kilometres and the China–Myanmar corridor is over 1100 kilometres, and both cross inhospitable terrain and politically unstable territories. The transit through Sikkim is, therefore, the most viable route for China to the Indian Ocean, and Sikkim becomes a good bet for China to overcome their Malacca Dilemma. The Chinese will, therefore, continue to make strenuous efforts to persuade India to open this route. Their offer to settle the India–China boundary in the Sikkim Sector as an 'early harvest' is basically linked to this objective.

If India accepts the idea, it will be akin to Adam accepting the proverbial forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden. The consequences could be potentially devastating. In a single diplomatic gambit, the Chinese will secure three prized objectives—direct overland access to the huge Indian domestic market; the shortest route to the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean; and never having to finalize the India–China boundary in any other sector since they can trade freely with India without finalizing a disputed frontier.

In a nutshell, giving them access through Sikkim (or for that matter through Nepal) might mean that China will have no compelling reason to seek a boundary settlement until a time of their choosing. Moreover, the opening of regular overland trade between India and China through Khamba Dzong and the Chumbi Valley will also, unquestionably, set off a chain of events that might compel the Royal Government of Bhutan to open its frontiers to the Chinese, and generate pressure from the Government of Bangladesh to allow transit through the Siliguri Corridor for trade with China. It will constitute the final